

HAYS COUNTY

San Marcos Police Department announces new APLR privacy safeguards

The announcement comes a little more than a week after the San Marcos City Council declined to add more automated license plate readers.

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SAN MARCOS, Texas — On Friday, the city of San Marcos shared new safeguards that police are implementing for automated license plate reader cameras (ALPRs).

In response to feedback from the community and the [San Marcos City Council](#), the city said the San Marcos Police Department (SMPD) is working to strengthen privacy protections when it comes to ALPRs.

"Building and maintaining public trust is fundamental to our mission," Police Chief Stan Standridge said in a statement. "As we leverage Flock ALPR technology to enhance

community safety, we will ensure that clear expectations and usage protocols for Flock ALPR data are regularly communicated and understood throughout the department, reinforcing our commitment to privacy and responsible data stewardship."

The city said the SMPD stopped automatically sharing ALPR data with outside agencies on June 9. Instead, that data will now only be shared upon request and with confirmation of a criminal investigation or prosecution. Agencies must complete a formal request process, including a non-disclosure agreement, before the data will be released.

The police department has also deactivated five ALPR cameras, leaving only the original 14 that were installed in 2022. A map of the final camera locations is available [online](#).

SMPD has also formalized an audit process to ensure ALPR data is "used appropriately as an SMPD investigative tool."

"While audits were not mandated under the original 2022 policy, a requirement for annual audits was added in the March 2025 revisions proposed by staff," the city said. "Turning off automatic data sharing with other law enforcement agencies allows the department to audit its own personnel directly. All inquiries into the ALPR system must now be tied to an active investigation and users will be required to enter both a reason for the inquiry and an associated case number."

SMPD is also working with Flock Safety and the city's legal team to amend the existing contract and prevent the collection of aggregated data unless expressly requested by the city.

The newly announced safeguards come a little more than a week after the San Marcos City Council [declined to add more ALPRs](#) in the city.

Some community members remain skeptical

Following the city's announcement on Friday, a local group called the Caldwell/Hays Education Fund (CHEF) – comprised of several former Mano Amiga staffers – released a statement expressing skepticism about the safeguards.

The statement reads:

"We remain troubled by SMPD's claim that license plate data will be released if 'tied to an active investigation' given that problematically flimsy standard. In April, dozens of people in Dripping Springs had their lives derailed in a traumatic raid because law enforcement alleged their connection to Tren de Aragua, which months later, no evidence has been provided to back the claim.

Following years of documented untrustworthiness and incompetence from SMPD – from dishonest depictions of the circumstances in their officers' killing of Malachi Williams, Rescue Eram and Jennifer Miller, to the wrongful yearslong jailing of Cyrus Gray and Devonte Amerson due to shoddy investigations – this agency has absolutely lost the benefit of the doubt from San Marcos residents."

